Kjell Gruner

(GROO-ner)

President and CEO
Volkswagen Group of America

Addressed as: **Dr. Gruner** | Office held since: **Dec. 2024**

A passionate and ambitious leader, Dr. Kjell Gruner is hoping his can-do attitude and attention to details will enlarge Volkswagen's footprint in the United States.

- **Driven to Build**
  Gruner is motivated by long-term impact. He describes himself as "more of a builder... someone who wants to create something, build something, and later sit by the campfire with his grandchildren and say: 'Hey, we did that.'"

- **Knowing America**
  Gruner is a close observer of American culture, sensitive to the importance of convenience to the American car owner. He knows how many meals Americans eat in their cars and insists that his cars' cup holders fit a Stanley cup.

Gruner has talked about his emotional connection to Volkswagen. In a LinkedIn post, he shared that his "very first car was a 1972 orange VW Beetle, a 1302L, followed by a 1978 VW Camper."

WHY THEY MATTER

As Volkswagen Group's top executive in North America, Gruner is keen on partnerships, innovation, and advice to revive the company's fortunes in a critical growth market.

- **Growing VW's Market Share**
  Gruner is making a big bet on America, aiming to double VW's market share to 10 percent by 2030. Its focus on electric vehicles has been undercut by President Trump's policies.

- **Seeking Cutting-Edge Partnerships**
  Gruner has forged strategic alliances, including an Uber partnership to deploy autonomous ID. Buzz vehicles, positioning VW at the forefront of mobility transformation.

As a former BCGer, Gruner has leveraged consultants throughout his career, including commissioning a recent study of the impact of Volkswagen and Audi dealerships on U.S. jobs.

MEETING WITH THEM

Gruner employs an approachable speaking style that balances executive authority with genuine warmth.

- **World Class Expertise**
  Gruner is unflashy about his mastery of the automobile industry, but will quickly impress with in-depth remarks on recent sales numbers, vehicle architecture, and prospects for the EV market.

- **Inclusive Storytelling**
  Gruner shares relatable experiences to underscore his points, often dropping diverse culture references such as James Dean, Legos, and cowboy boot makers in Houston, Texas.

When confronted with sensitive questions, he alternates between disarming candor ("I can tell you this is a very very difficult question") to gentle evasion ("unfortunately, I cannot give you a specific answer").

ON THEIR MIND

- **Cost-cutting Measures**
  The Volkswagen Group is planning further cost-cutting measures to improve key financial indicators. This is likely to affect existing and planned electric cars for the U.S. market.

- **VW Deliveries Fall in North America**
  In early October, Volkswagen reported that its North American Q3 deliveries fell 9.8 percent to 246,900 vehicles. The drop was offset by gains in Europe, South America, Middle East and Africa, as well as in the Asia Pacific region with the exception of China.

- **Chattanooga Strike Vote**
  After more than 13 months of negotiations, Volkswagen workers in Chattanooga, Tennessee have announced a strike authorization vote to take place on Tuesday, October 28 and Wednesday, October 29.

- **Automotive USA 2025**
  Gruner is one of the speakers at Reuters's Automotive USA 2025 in Detroit. He will be interviewed by David Shepardson, a corporate regulation reporter, on Wednesday, October 29.

DRAGO

NETWORK

Gruner is deeply knowledgeable about international markets, breaking down the differences between European, Korean, and American customers while analyzing opportunities and challenges in China.

In a recent podcast, Gruner detailed how he seeks to find “synergies” between different markets, leveraging platforms in one country to develop cars for other regions. For example, he revealed that Chinese customer preferences and American ones are more similar than European and American ones.

Gruner’s hard-earned reputation for excellence won him quick acceptance at Volkswagen Group of America.

Since his announcement as CEO, his colleagues have showered him with praise for his “extensive know-how in exploiting and expediting growth opportunities in North America.” He earned similar plaudits from colleagues at Porsche.

CONTROVERSIES

While a well-regarded leader in the sector, Gruner faces challenges in his new role at Volkswagen.

- **ID. Buzz Rollout**
  The company’s EV reboot of its iconic vintage van has been plagued by problems, including reaching dealers years late, coming in over budget, and performing poorly compared to other new EVs. In addition, all vehicles shipped to the U.S. were recalled in April because the third-row seats were too broad, allowing three passengers to squeeze into a space with only two seat belts.

- **Dealer Litigation**
  VW and Audi dealers in Florida and California have sued Scout Motors (a VW affiliate), alleging violations of state franchise law. While Volkswagen Group of America has no operational role in Scout’s management, the lawsuits represent another challenge for the brand.

Gruner’s rapid career moves have raised some eyebrows. His departure from Rivian after only 11 months was part of a broader executive exodus at the company, though he claimed he was "pursuing other opportunities." This followed his relatively brief three-year tenure as CEO at Porsche North America.

DRAGO

CAREER HIGHLIGHTS

- **President & CEO**, Volkswagen Group of America (2024 - present)
- **Chief Commercial Officer & President Business Growth**, Rivian Automotives (2023 to 2024)
- **President and CEO**, Porsche Cars North America (2020 to 2023)
- **Global Chief Marketing Officer**, Porsche AG (2010 to 2020)
- **Director of Strategy**, Mercedes-Benz Cars (2004 to 2010)
- **Senior Marketing/Strategy Roles**, Porsche AG (1999 to 2004)
- **Consultant**, Boston Consulting Group (1997 to 1999)

BIO

Gruner's passion for automobiles began early, climbing up the corporate ladder as the industry has evolved over the decades. Born in 1969 in Germany, Gruner has lived and worked in several American cities, including Atlanta, Georgia; Irvine, California; Mount Pleasant, Michigan; and Reston, Virginia.

- **Marketing Degrees**
  Gruner holds a PhD in Marketing from WHU – Otto Beisheim School of Management and an MS in Industrial Engineering from Karlsruhe Institute of Technology. He also studied Business Administration at Central Michigan University. In 2000, he co-authored a peer-reviewed paper entitled "Does Customer Interaction Enhance New Product Success?"

- **Car Collector**
  Gruner often talks about his passion for cars, admitting that "it has been fun to own three different Porsches over the years. I have owned my 1994 968 cabriolet for 20 years." He even likes attending car shows, conceding that it is an "unpopular opinion."

Gruner is married with at least two children. His wife also works in the automobile industry, dedicating more than 24 years to Porsche. Gruner says he broke his rule to avoid personal matters on Linkedin by celebrating his eldest daughter's graduation from the University of Melbourne earlier this year. Gruner speaks German and English.

NOTES